

RANKING THE PRESIDENTS

KALAM'S IMMENSE POPULARITY FURTHER ESTABLISHES THAT NON-POLITICAL PRESIDENTS SCORE HIGH. THE RATING WAS DONE BY THE EDITORS OF INDIA TODAY.

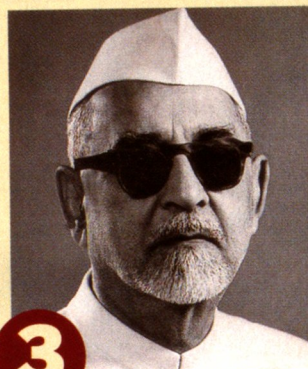


S. RADHAKRISHNAN
(1962-1967)

THE PHILOSOPHER

Gave intellectual aura, earned respect of the political establishment.

Constitutional Propriety	8*
Independence	9
Integrity	9
Stature	9
New Initiatives	8

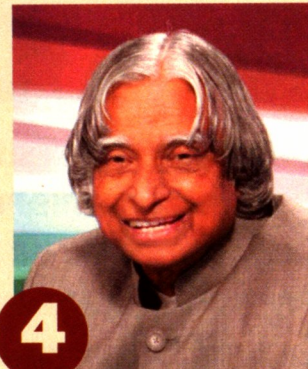


ZAKIR HUSAIN
(1967-1969)

FINE BALANCE

The first Muslim President, Indira's choice against the Syndicate.

Constitutional Propriety	7
Independence	6
Integrity	8
Stature	8
New Initiatives	7

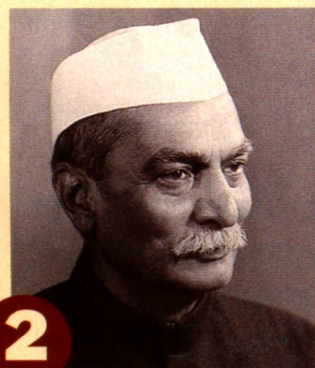


A.P.J. ABDUL KALAM
(2002-2007)

PEOPLE'S PRESIDENT

Demystified the office, established an intimate link with the people.

Constitutional Propriety	7
Independence	6
Integrity	7
Stature	6
New Initiatives	7



RAJENDRA PRASAD
(1950-1962)

CONSTITUTIONAL CHECK

Had serious differences with Nehru, but still got a second term.

Constitutional Propriety	8
Independence	8
Integrity	9
Stature	9
New Initiatives	6



GIANI ZAIL SINGH
(1982-1987)

INCONVENIENT LOYALIST

The Indira loyalist eventually turned against her son Rajiv.

Constitutional Propriety	6
Independence	6
Integrity	6
Stature	5
New Initiatives	5

● Numbers in circles are ranks *Scores for the five parameters are on a scale of 0 to 10

to a cross-section of India, mostly ordinary citizens. He transformed the Rashtrapati Bhavan, as he says in the accompanying interview, into a people's Bhavan. He once invited 6,000 farmers; another time, he played host to 250 policemen from all over India, and also invited postmen and village sarpanches. But those he enjoyed playing host to were people with problems who needed his help, those with promise and talent, and, of course, students from all over who sat spellbound at his feet while he lectured on what they could contribute to the country and his vision for 2020, when, he forcefully believes, India could be a developed nation. "He has been one of the

finest and certainly the best-loved and most-respected presidents," said former attorney-general Soli Sorabjee.

The reason for that universal appeal was evident on the last night of his presidency, which Kalam spent huddled over his computer in his favourite room at the Rashtrapati Bhavan, a bedroom turned into a hi-tech study bristling with multi-media devices from where he could keep in touch with the nation. A few hours earlier, he had converted a routine farewell telecast to the nation into a stirring "I have a dream" address that laid down forcefully his 10-point vision of India in 2020. It was typical Kalam style to never waste an opportunity to get his message across.

Says Amit Mitra, secretary-general of FICCI: "As President, his biggest achievement was accessibility and openness. He gave a new vision of accountability to the highest office of the country. Within 24 hours of e-mailing him, you would get a reply."

His tenure was certainly not a bed of Mughal Garden roses. Indeed, he was not the original choice for president in 2002 when the Atal Bihari Vajpayee-led NDA was in power. It first seemed a three-way battle among former governor P.C. Alexander, the then incumbent K.R. Narayanan and the then vice-president Krishna Kant. While the Congress was busy trying to score brownie points by raising objec-